“My father watched many of his friends be killed,” she wrote. “I know that he must have died inside a little each time. But his explanation to me was: ‘You did what you had to do and you kept on going.’”

All her life, Lisa said, she had heard stories from her father about D day. “He never considered himself or what he had done as anything special,” she said. “He was just an ordinary guy, with immigrant Italian parents who never really had enough money. But he was a proud man—proud of his heritage, proud of his country, proud that he had fought in World War II and proud that he lived through D-Day.”

We arranged for Lisa and her family to be a part of our delegation and her words, speaking for her father, somehow seemed to speak for all of the men who had risked their lives that morning in the defense of liberty, including those lying beneath the endless horizon of white crosses. “He made me feel the fear of being on that boat waiting to land,” I said, quoting Lisa’s letter. “I can smell the ocean and feel the seasickness. I can see the looks on his fellow soldiers’ faces, the fear, the anguish, the uncertainty of what lay ahead. And when they landed, I can feel the strength and courage of the men who took those first steps through the tide to what must have surely looked like instant death . . .”

After a few minutes, it was all but impossible to go on. My voice began to crack. But I managed to get through it and was glad when I reached the end: “Through the words of his loving daughter, who is here with us today, a D-day veteran has shown us the meaning of this day far better than any presidents can. It is enough for us to say about Private Zanatta and all the men of honor and courage who fought beside him four decades ago: We will always remember. We will always be proud. We will always be prepared, so we may always be free.”